

# POST-COLD WAR

**The Berlin Wall fell** in November 1989. By 1991, the Soviet Union had ceased to exist and the Cold War was over. The end of this era of international tension resulted in large scale reductions in military forces, with thousands of tanks and armored vehicles scrapped or sold. Many nations retired large fleets of outmoded tanks, some dating back to the 1950s, and purchased modern, secondhand vehicles at a discount. The former communist nations of Eastern Europe also began restructuring their militaries along Western lines, with many joining NATO.

Armored vehicles found a new role in conflicts in the former Yugoslavia. United Nations and NATO peacekeepers used their presence to protect civilians, and to intimidate and keep apart warring factions.

Outside Europe, where security threats were ongoing, tank development continued, with nations such as Israel, South Korea, Japan, China, Turkey, India, and Pakistan developing new vehicles. Older tanks have continued

to prove their usefulness in conflicts across the world, especially against irregular forces.

Advanced technology has begun to play a larger role in armored vehicles. Developments in cameras, thermal sights, and networked communications have increased situational awareness for crews, both around their vehicles and across the battlefield. Increasingly powerful antitank weapons, especially in urban environments such as Chechnya and Syria, have spurred improvements in protection, including Active Protection Systems. Some of these can automatically shoot back at incoming projectiles, while others can interrupt guidance systems or “hide” the tank. These suggest that, although its place on the battlefield is again threatened, the tank will endure.



△ **Second Gulf War magazine covers**  
Tank combat in the invasion of Iraq was often characterized by US M1 Abrams defeating Iraqi forces in older Soviet armor.

“**Tanks being deployed far forward** is an indication of **offensive action**; tanks in depth is an indication of **defensive action**.”

NORMAN SCHWARZKOPF, FORMER US ARMY GENERAL

◁ **A Merkava IV** of the Israel Defense Forces maneuvers with a mine-clearing device attached to the front of its hull.

## Key events

- ▷ **July 17, 1992** The CFE Treaty limits the amount of military equipment NATO and the Warsaw Pact may possess.
- ▷ **April 29, 1994** Operation Bøllebank is launched by Danish forces in Bosnia, the first use of the Leopard 1 in combat.
- ▷ **December 31, 1994** Russia attempts to capture Grozny, Chechnya using armored units, with heavy casualties.
- ▷ **March 2003** American and British armored forces invade Iraq.



△ **Iraq War at night, 2004**  
A Bradley M2A2 infantry fighting vehicle opens fire in Samarra, Iraq.

- ▷ **July 2006** In the Israeli-Hezbollah War, Israeli weaknesses in armored warfare are exposed by Hezbollah's sophisticated tactics and equipment.
- ▷ **September 2006** NATO first deploys tanks, Canadian Leopard C2s, to Afghanistan. Danish Leopard 2A5s and USMC M1A1 Abrams also fight there.
- ▷ **2011-present** The Syrian Civil War sees intense urban fighting between Syrian Army armored units and rebels.
- ▷ **August 2014** Modern Russian tanks are observed in fighting in Eastern Ukraine between the government and Russian-backed separatists.
- ▷ **2015** In the Saudi-led intervention in Yemen, Houthi rebels use modern ATGMs to destroy Saudi tanks.
- ▷ **May 2015** A World War II-era T-34/85 and SU-100 are seen in use in Yemen.